I started walking down the center of the room, looking for an empty seat among the folding chairs that had been set up on both sides of the aisle.

I saw an open seat and turned toward it; although it took me a moment to realize it, something had been planned: As soon as I sat down every member on the board who had been sitting on that side of the aisle got up and moved across to the other side, leaving me to sit alone.

Shortly after that, I learned the group had become another front for the Communist Party in Hollywood.

The Communists gained control of the groups through hard work and good organization—a minority of perhaps one percent moving in, coming to meetings early, and staying late and volunteering to do the hard work for the well-meaning liberals (like me) who were its members.

The strike and the efforts to gain control over HICCASP and other organizations had a profound effect on me. More than anything else, it was the Communists' attempted takeover of Hollywood and its worldwide weekly audience of more than five hundred million people that led me to accept a nomination to serve as president of the Screen Actors Guild and, indirectly at least, set me on the road that would lead me into politics.

One of the best reviews I ever got didn't involve a movie but came from a fellow actor testifying in court. Sterling Hayden, who'd been among those flirting with Communism before later renouncing it, said: "Ronald Reagan was a one-man battalion of opposition" to the attempted Communist takeover of Hollywood during the 1946 strike.

In the end, we stopped the Communists cold in Hollywood, but there was a dark side to the battle; unfortunately, it was a story with victims as well as villains.

Some members of the House Un-American Activities Committee came to Hollywood searching more for personal publicity than they were for Communists. Many fine people